WEEK 05 / GAMING'S IMPACT ON PEOPLE AND SOCIETY

Representation, Inclusion, and Accessibility

Analyzing representation and inclusivity in gaming.

This week we analyze representation and inclusivity in gaming, discussing how different groups are portrayed and the efforts to create a more inclusive gaming environment, including the role of features that make games more accessible to all players. This includes assistive technologies and design principles. We will also take a look at character design, storylines, representation among the game development community, and community dynamics.

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43 RESOURCES / 1 TOPIC

TOPIC 01

Representation and Inclusion

REQUIRED

Tropes vs. Women in Video Games

YOUTUBE PLAYLIST | 83 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PLn4ob_5_ttEaZWIYcx7VKiFheMSEp1gbq

Some highlights:

Female Sidekicks and Companions:

Female companions, like Elizabeth in Bioshock Infinite, often serve significant narrative roles but are reduced to basic gameplay functions, such as being a "glorified door opener".

Despite possessing powers, they are mechanically limited to menial tasks and can feel like tools or "sexualized slot machines".

Yorda in ICO is a quintessential example of the "damsel escort mission," where a largely helpless female character accompanies the player, often feeling like a burden requiring protection and assistance to traverse the environment (like Ashley Graham in Resident Evil 4 or Ellie needing help crossing water in The Last of Us).

\- I've watched the gameplay of RE:4 (not played it myself) and been so bothered by Ashley's role…

The pattern of men helping or carrying women in these situations reinforces sexist ideas about men as protectors and women needing protection.

Female characters can also be used as rudimentary tools in gameplay (e.g., Princess Ruto as a switch weight). In Metal Gear Solid 5, a woman is one of four sidekick options and the others are all non-human.

Female companions often act as "cheerleaders," boosting the player's ego, interactions that are rarely mutually supportive. They are typically not designed for players to develop genuine relationships with.

Competent female companions whose skills are equal to the player (Tess in The Last of Us, female squad members in Gears of War) challenge harmful ideas.

More games are subverting these patterns by providing supporting characters who feel like separate individuals with their own feelings and desires (One Night Stand, Riley in The Last Of Us: Left Behind).

When female supporting characters lack depth and exist primarily to be protected or ordered around, they reinforce harmful ideas and fail as characters; games should reflect that people are more than tools or burdens.

Body Diversity in Video Games:

Lack of diversity in female body types is common across games like Ultra Street Fighter IV, League of Legends, and Dota 2, where male characters exhibit a wide range of body shapes and proportions, while female characters are predominantly slender, often with prominent breasts, representing a standard of conventional attractiveness.

Male characters' physiques often communicate their personality or abilities, but female characters are frequently limited to a single body type designed for sexual appeal to presumed straight male players.

This limited representation is harmful as it links women's value to their desirability to men and reinforces narrow cultural beauty standards.

The absence of diverse female bodies reinforces the false idea that women who don't match the cultural beauty standard are less valuable.

This creativity limitation also affects age representation; older male heroes are common, but playable female characters are almost always young, again tied to sexual appeal, suggesting women's value decreases with age.

While positive examples of female characters with different body types or ages exist (Alyssa in Life is Strange, Agnes MacBean in Assassin's Creed Syndicate, Kreia in Knights of the Old Republic II), they are rare in major contemporary games.

Later additions to Overwatch like Mei, Zarya (different body types), and Ana (older woman of color) are encouraging steps, but developers must actively work towards the same diversity for female bodies as for male characters.

Liberating female characters from narrow beauty standards can make games more interesting and help portray all women as valuable, autonomous individuals.

Animation and Inclusion Challenges:

Including female combatants is preferable to their absence. Violence against women in games is problematic when they are specifically victimized for being women. When women are active participants on equal footing, fighting them (like in Street Fighter) is not violence against women.

However, female combatants are often sexualized, making attacks against them feel like gendered violence (e.g., Saints Row The Third's "Whored Mode," Wolfenstein's Elite Guard, Hitman Absolution's Saints, Metal Gear Solid 4's Beauty & the Beast unit). Violence against female characters should not be "sexy".

Female combatants should be presented simply as combatants alongside men on equal footing, without sexualization, as seen with female police in Bioshock Infinite or gang members in Assassin's Creed Syndicate.

Movement and the Male Gaze:

Character movement can reinforce or resist gender stereotypes. In Destiny, male and female characters' sitting animations differ: male characters sit simply, suggesting confidence, while female characters sit in a delicate, stylized manner.

Movement is used to communicate personality and skills. However, female characters' movement is often used to exude sexuality for the presumed straight male player.

This sexualizing walk pattern is a manifestation of the male gaze, a concept where visual arts are structured around a presumed masculine viewer.

The solution is not equal sexualization of men.

There is potential for female characters to be animated emphasizing personality traits like strength or grace, rather than being framed as sex objects (e.g., Ellie in The Last of Us). Equality means treating all characters as full human beings, not reducing them to objectified parts.

Sexualized and Impractical Clothing:

Clothing is a primary way designers communicate a character's importance. While female heroes are often in dangerous situations requiring practical gear, their outfits are frequently sexualized and absurdly impractical (e.g., Ivy in Soulcalibur, Cammy in Street Fighter, Jessica Sherawat in Resident Evil: Revelations).

This contributes to the hyper-sexualization of female characters, valuing them primarily for sexual characteristics.

Conflating sexualization with power is harmful, suggesting women's power comes from being desirable to men and that empowered women's sexuality is always available to men. This myth encourages believing sexualization is the route to equality.

Solving this problem is not difficult, and some games (Dark Souls, XCOM, Assassin's Creed Syndicate) use practical armor/clothing for female characters.

Impractical clothing encourages viewing female characters as sex objects. Practical clothing and non-sexualized expressions of sexuality encourage viewing them as people.

Exotification and Racism:

Far Cry 3 features Citra, a woman of color presented as a tribal warrior goddess who embodies a blend of sexist and racist stereotypes, functioning as a sexual motivator/reward for the player while her mystical powers and body paint evoke harmful notions about tribal cultures and women of color.

This is an example of exotification, treating a group as inherently different, alluring, and strange, often involving sexual fetishization based on false racial notions.

The Diablo III witch doctor, represented by black characters, relies on visual stereotypes of tribal warriors, perpetuating centuries-old racist imagery. Fighting games like Street Fighter IV feature characters like Elena who combine sexualization with vague suggestions of tribal culture and stereotypical mystical traits.

These depictions are cultural appropriation, reducing complex cultures to stereotypical signifiers used as shorthand for "exotic," reinforcing damaging myths that contribute to the marginalization of women of color today.

Respectful portrayals of women of color whose cultural backgrounds are acknowledged are rare. While some games feature black male protagonists or acknowledge racism (Watchdogs 2, Mafia 3), positive examples for women of color are limited.

Games like 1979 Revolution and Never Alone show how cultural history can be incorporated respectfully, counteracting stereotypes and enriching player understanding. Games should strive for thoughtful, humanizing representations of people of color.

Sinister Seductress/Demonization of Femaleness:

Alternatively, female characters' attractiveness or seductiveness can make them threatening, as seen with mythological Sirens or characters like Morinth in Mass Effect 2, whose mating is deadly.

This "temptress" tradition includes characters whose sexuality is presented as a threat or weapon (Dark Queen, Elizebet, Layla), rooted in ancient misogynistic ideas about women being deceptive and evil.

Games sometimes combine these types, initially presenting attractive female characters whose true forms are revealed as monstrous (Brothers: A Tale of Two Sons, DmC, Ms. Splosion Man). This implies female sexuality is deceptive or threatening.

When male heroes defeat these characters, the victory is often gendered, reasserting male dominance. Killings can be graphically sexualized.

It is possible to have female villains whose evil isn't tied to gender or sexuality (Kreia, GLaDOS, Carmen Sandiego).

- Using these tropes uncritically perpetuates harmful, false notions about women being misleading, manipulative, and that female sexuality should be feared and controlled.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.

REQUIRED

The gaming industry needs more women developers

ARTICLE | 4 MIN

https://moonshot.news/news/diversity-inclusion/the-gaming-industry-needs-more-women-developers/

Summarizes a 2023 report from the Gena Davis Institute of Gender in Media. Quote: “Scarce and sexualized representation of women in games may stem from women’s underrepresentation among game developers. Similarly, racialized characters that reinforce harmful tropes, or culturally inauthenticity or insensitive characters may stem from the underrepresentation of people of color among game developers.” That’s not an excuse, but is certainly one argument for more diversity among game developers.

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REQUIRED

Inclusive Character Creator

YOUTUBE | 18 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FPJQk88G8Ks&ab_channel=GameDevsofColorExpo

A talk from the 2022 Game Devs of Color Expo about a thesis project building a more inclusive character creator, which discusses discrimination within in-game character creators. It highlights some positive examples from games and game development tools. This is a fascinating talk with great points, discussed complexities and limitations, future directions for what the speaker refers to as a framework for people to use to build their own character creators.

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REQUIRED

The Power of Play: The Portrayal and Performance of Race in Video Games

BOOK EXCERPT | 63 MIN

https://com427spring2017ncsu.wordpress.com/wp-content/uploads/2017/01/2007-everett__watkins-powerofplay-raceingames.pdf

An excerpt from The Ecology of Games: Connecting Youth, Games, and Learning (https://mitpress.mit.edu/9780262693646/the-ecology-of-games/), edited by Katie Salen.

Highlights:
- Titles like GTA simulate gritty urban environments with black and Latino characters.
  These games often rely on exaggerated stereotypes: hypermasculinity, criminality, and exoticism.
  Developers market these elements as “authentic” urban culture, even though they draw from pre-existing media stereotypes.
  RPZs are game environments where racial messages are taught through interaction, not just representation.
  The authors explore how gameplay-such as missions and role-playing-reinforces ideas about race.
- GTA, in particular, is criticized for presenting black and Latino characters in environments that normalize violence and deviance.
  The concept of “digital minstrelsy” describes how players perform race through gameplay-similar to blackface in minstrel shows.
  Players, especially white players, are invited to inhabit racialized characters and act out racialized behaviors for entertainment.
  Character roles: Black and Latino characters are more visible in these games, but often as gang members, athletes, or criminals.
  Gender: Black and Latina women are typically portrayed as hypersexualized, victims, or accessories to male characters.
  Sound and setting: Audio and environment design (graffiti, gunfire, hip-hop music) contribute to a “realistic” portrayal of urban chaos.
  Games can reinforce harmful stereotypes, even while appearing “authentic.”
  To shift this, there must be broader access to game creation tools and more racial diversity in the game industry.
  Addressing race in games isn’t just about changing content-it’s about changing who gets to create it.

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REQUIRED

The Video Game Industry's Problem With Racial Diversity

ARTICLE | 5 MIN

https://link.gale.com/apps/doc/A467695662/CPI?u=maine_augusta&sid=bookmark-CPI&xid=e30de855

This article examines the significant lack of racial diversity within the video game industry (76% of game developers are white), specifically highlighting the scarcity and narrow typecasting of Black protagonists. The authors argue that while Black consumers represent a large portion of the gaming public, they are rarely portrayed beyond harmful stereotypes or secondary roles, which limits the medium's potential for authentic storytelling. Central to this issue is a stark demographic imbalance among creators; only a tiny fraction of game developers are Black, leading to a shortage of the insider perspectives necessary for nuanced representation. Ultimately, the article advocates for increased inclusivity in the workforce to foster innovative narratives and provide younger generations with more diverse and aspirational digital role models. Quote: “Some argue that racial diversity is more important in video games than in TV or film. Gamers can develop a visceral relationship with characters in a way that is more compelling than in other media.”

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.

REQUIRED

GDC 2024 Report: More Of The Same…

ARTICLE | 3 MIN

https://www.womeningames.org/gdc-2024-report-more-of-the-same/

From Women in Games, an organization that promotes more diversity in game development and esports, this article summarizes learnings related to diversity from the 2024 State of the Game Industry report from the Game Developers Conference. While finding DEI efforts to be successful, the percentage with this view had decreased from the previous year. “When it comes to gender representation, men still make up over two-thirds of game developers-23% of developers surveyed are women, 21% are from the LGBTQ+ community and 5% are non-binary.”

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.

REQUIRED

Beyond Solitaire Podcast 103: Adrienne Shaw on LGBTQ+ Representation in Video Games

YOUTUBE | 54 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3qFptT--IC0&ab_channel=BeyondSolitaire

This podcast episode featuring Dr. Adrienne Shaw, a professor specializing in media studies and production, focusing on representation of marginalized groups in video games, particularly the LGBTQ+ community. Dr. Shaw discusses her academic work, including her book "Gaming at the Edge" which challenges traditional views on identification and representation in games, and her significant project, the LGBTQ Game Archive, a database documenting such content since the 1980s. She also touches on the challenges of preserving older digital media, the complexity of representation in games versus other media, and the importance of diversity in the gaming industry.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.

REQUIRED

The history of LGBTQ representation in video games

ARTICLE | 11 MIN

https://outinjersey.net/the-history-of-lgbtq-representation-in-video-games/

As the name suggests, reviews the history of LGBTQ characters in video games. Some highlights:
- Earliest lesbian character may have been in 1986 computer game Moonmist
- Caper in the Castro, by most accounts the first LGBTQ video game ever created, was released in 1989
- Also in 1989, a trans character and a gay character were featured in the game Circuit's Edge
- 1992 saw the release of adventure game GayBlade
- 1995 game Earthbound for Super Nintendo features a character that the creator later revealed was intended to be gay
- Billy and Brad from Wild Arms 2, Jaciel and Deyanira from Elder Scrolls II: Daggerfall, and Front Mission 2's Rocky and Ash are assumed to be queer, but unconfirmed
- Briefly shares the story of how The Sims came to include same-sex relationships
- 1998, Fallout 2 became the first video game to allow same-sex marriages
- 2004, Fable and The Sims 2 allow same-sex marriages
- 2013, 63 games released with LGBTQ characters or content
- 2015, Leelah Alcorn, a 17-year-old transgender girl, committed suicide; Jam For Leelah, a "game jam" (an event where individuals or teams create video games within a short, often limited, time frame, typically ranging from 24 hours to a few days), results in 21 new trans positive video games created over the course of a month

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REQUIRED

How the first LGBTQ+ video game was given a second life

ARTICLE/TRANSCRIPT | 5 MIN

https://www.npr.org/2023/01/27/1151702216/how-the-first-lgbtq-video-game-was-given-a-second-life

NPR interview with CM Ralph, creator of Caper in the Castro, and Dr. Adrienne Shaw, about the game, its development, and restoration.

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REQUIRED

Video game creators are working to make games more accessible for disabled people

AUDIO/TRANSCRIPT | 6 MIN

https://www.npr.org/2024/06/09/nx-s1-4995567/video-game-creators-are-working-to-make-games-more-accessible-for-disabled-people

NPR story regarding adding accessibility options to video games in order to make them enjoyable by people with disabilities.

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REQUIRED

What Makes Celeste's Assist Mode Special

YOUTUBE | 15 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NInNVEHj_G4&list=PLc38fcMFcV_vvWOhMDriBlVocTZ8mKQzR

This video explores the tension between a developer's singular creative vision and the necessity of player accessibility. While creators often design difficult or specific mechanics to ensure a particular emotional impact, the author argues that clear communication allows for flexible options without compromising that original intent. By examining games like Celeste, Darkest Dungeon, and SOMA, the video illustrates how labels, timing, and transparency can provide an "assist mode" for those who need it while still signaling the intended way to play. Ultimately, the author suggests that when developers trust their players with honest information, they can empower a diverse audience to enjoy a game without forcing them to take on the role of the game designer.

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REQUIRED

Accessible Design VS Accessibility Settings - Access-Ability

YOUTUBE | 10 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oYXR6zLEjPk

While high-profile titles often boast a massive list of accessibility settings to fix problems after a game is built, this source argues that true progress lies in accessible design, where inclusivity is baked into the core experience from day one. Rather than relying solely on optional filters or toggles, developers are increasingly using inherent design choices-such as adding unique shapes to color-coded puzzles or utilizing spatial audio-to ensure the game is naturally playable for everyone without requiring extra adjustments. This shift represents a move toward proactive development over reactive solutions, suggesting that the sheer number of menu options is an incomplete metric for how welcoming a game actually is to disabled players. Ultimately, the goal is to balance customizable features with a baseline of universal access, moving the industry toward a future where games are fundamentally built to be inclusive by default.

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REQUIRED

A history of adaptive esports

ARTICLE | 5 MIN

https://blogs.und.edu/und-today/2024/08/a-history-of-adaptive-esports/

This article explores the deep-rooted history of adaptive gaming, tracing the origins of inclusive technology back to the 1980s arcade era. By highlighting the story of Rob Marince and his brother's invention of a sip-and-puff controller, the text illustrates how early innovations provided people with disabilities a sense of community and personal achievement. The narrative then shifts to the modern landscape, detailing the transition from these grassroots efforts to mainstream esports organizations and major industry advancements in hardware accessibility. Ultimately, the author emphasizes that while the path toward inclusion has been non-linear, contemporary developments like customizable control schemes and specialized consoles ensure that gaming remains a powerful platform for diverse athletes.

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REQUIRED

Video games are more than entertainment - AbleGamers Impact: Elvin

ARTICLE | 3 MIN

https://ablegamers.org/ablegamers-impact-elvin-r/

This article details the work of AbleGamers, a charity dedicated to fostering social inclusion and improving mental health for people with disabilities through the power of video games. By highlighting the story of a gamer named Elvin, the article illustrates how personalized adaptive equipment and peer counseling can help individuals overcome physical barriers to play, effectively reducing stress and social isolation. Beyond individual support, the organization seeks to create inclusive communities where technology serves as a bridge for connection and emotional well-being. Ultimately, the text defines gaming as a transformative tool for rehabilitation and joy rather than just a simple form of entertainment.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.
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REQUIRED

Can I Play That?

WEB SITE

https://caniplaythat.com/

Can I Play That? is a specialized digital platform and non-profit organization dedicated to evaluating and promoting accessibility within the gaming industry. The website includes expert game reviews, technical evaluations of adaptive hardware, and breaking news regarding inclusive software updates. By highlighting specialized features like high contrast modes and customizable controls, the site serves as a vital resource guide for players with diverse physical and cognitive needs. Ultimately, the publication aims to empower the community through advocacy and education, fostering a landscape where developers and disabled gamers can collaborate to remove barriers to play.

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REQUIRED

Another World Conquered by Video Games: Retirees

ARTICLE | 8 MIN

https://maine.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01MAINE_INST/1oa9cn5/cdi_proquest_newspapers_433527823

This is a slightly dated article that discusses the growing interest among older people in video games. We're going to discuss this more when we talk about gaming and medicine in a couple of weeks.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Accessibility options for The Last of Us Part II

ARTICLE | 8 MIN

https://www.playstation.com/en-id/games/the-last-of-us-part-ii/accessibility/

This guide details the extensive accessibility feature set created by Naughty Dog for The Last of Us Part II, designed to ensure a wide range of players can enjoy the title. The document is structured around three primary presets tailored for vision, hearing, and motor needs, while also offering over sixty individual settings for full control customization and fine-tuning. Key themes include the removal of traditional barriers through navigation assistance, text-to-speech, and combat accessibility options that modify gameplay difficulty to suit personal requirements. Ultimately, the source serves as a comprehensive manual for users to build a personalized gameplay experience that accommodates diverse physical and sensory abilities.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

From Blind Driving Assists to One Touch Driving, Meet The Most Accessible Forza Motorsport Ever

ARTICLE | 5 MIN

https://news.xbox.com/en-us/2023/04/27/forza-motorsport-accessibility-features-blind-driving/

This article details the extensive accessibility features integrated into the latest Forza Motorsport, positioning it as the most inclusive entry in the racing franchise to date. Developed by Turn 10 Studios, the game introduces groundbreaking Blind Driving Assists that utilize audio cues to help low-vision players navigate tracks, alongside a One Touch Driving system that simplifies complex controller inputs for those with mobility challenges. The article serves as a comprehensive guide to the studio's inclusive design philosophy, highlighting secondary tools like screen narration, colorblind filters, and customizable subtitles. By offering these diverse settings as a suite of options rather than a separate mode, the developers aim to ensure that players of all ability levels can experience the realism and thrill of competitive racing.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

2025 Video Game Accessibility Recap - Access-Ability

YOUTUBE | 46 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sO76gjNPD5E

This video provides a comprehensive review of the advancements in video game accessibility throughout the year 2025, framed as a transition from dramatic breakthroughs to industry-wide standardization. The creator highlights a shift toward sustainable development, noting how major publishers have begun collaborating on unified accessibility tags and open-source tools to identify photosensitivity risks or simulate colorblindness. Detailed evaluations of specific titles, such as Assassin’s Creed Shadows and Doom: The Dark Ages, illustrate a growing trend toward granular gameplay customization and the inclusion of emotional tone tags in subtitles.

Beyond software, the video examines innovative hardware like the Xbox adaptive joystick and the modular Proteus controller, emphasizing that affordability and physical flexibility are essential for inclusive design. Ultimately, the video serves as both a historical record of disability representation in media and a call for developers to view accessibility as an ongoing post-launch commitment rather than a static release-day feature.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

How Blind Gamers Changed Madden

YOUTUBE | 8 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UWNGU2CRtio

While the gaming industry has historically ignored marginalized players, trailblazing engineers and charities are now prioritizing gaming accessibility to ensure everyone can play. A pivotal moment occurred when Electronic Arts established a dedicated division to support blind and visually impaired gamers, leading to the implementation of tactile rumble cues and visual aids in major titles like Madden. Beyond software, the movement includes hardware innovations such as Nintendo's historic hands-free controller and modern organizations that design customized input devices tailored to specific physical needs. Ultimately, these efforts aim to remove barriers through inclusive design, proving that video games can be adapted for any level of physical or sensory ability.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Accessibility of Communications in Video Games

ARTICLE | 6 MIN

https://www.fcc.gov/consumers/guides/accessibility-communications-video-games

The Twenty-First Century Communications and Video Accessibility Act mandates that advanced communications services, such as voice and text chat within video games, must be accessible and usable for individuals with disabilities. To comply with these federal requirements, game developers must integrate features like text-to-speech or automated captions or ensure their software functions with specialized peripheral equipment. This guide from the FCC clarifies that while these rules specifically target interpersonal communication tools rather than general gameplay, companies are obligated to provide accessible documentation and support services to all users. Ultimately, the guide serves as a resource for players to understand their rights, providing a clear framework for resolving disputes through the FCC if a gaming platform fails to meet these inclusivity standards.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Game Accessibility Guidelines

WEB SITE

https://gameaccessibilityguidelines.com/

This resource serves as a comprehensive collaborative framework designed to help developers create video games that are usable by individuals with a diverse range of disabilities and impairments. To make the content manageable, the site organizes its advice into three tiers of complexity, ranging from simple design tweaks to sophisticated technical adaptations. By providing clear examples and categorized lists, the guide aims to eliminate unnecessary exclusion in the gaming community. Ultimately, the project advocates for inclusive design as a standard practice, ensuring that interactive entertainment is accessible and enjoyable for the widest possible audience.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

IGDA Game Accessibility Special Interest Group

WEB SITE

https://igda-gasig.org/

The IGDA Game Accessibility Special Interest Group is a long-standing volunteer organization dedicated to removing unnecessary barriers that prevent people with disabilities from enjoying video games. By fostering a global community through outreach and education, the group provides developers with the principles needed to integrate inclusive design early in the creative process. The site serves as a resource hub, highlighting industry-wide progress through conference recaps and roundtables that discuss the future of sustainable accessibility. Ultimately, the group aims to align the efforts of many contributors to ensure gaming is a universal experience for players of all abilities.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Game Devs of Color Expo YouTube Channel

YOUTUBE CHANNEL

https://www.youtube.com/@GDoCExpo

Archived talks from past Game Devs of Color Expos.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Game Devs of Color Expo Website

WEB SITE

https://www.gamedevsofcolorexpo.com/

Information about the expo.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

LGBTQ Video Game Archive

WEB SITE

https://lgbtqgamearchive.com/

A database maintained by Dr. Adrienne Shaw documenting such content since the 1980s.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Gaming Representation: Race, Gender, and Sexuality in Video Games ed. by Jennifer Malkowski and TreaAndrea M. Russworm, and: Woke Gaming: Digital Challenges to Oppression and Social Injustice ed. by Kishonna L. Gray and David J. Leonard

REVIEW

https://maine.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01MAINE_INST/1oa9cn5/cdi_crossref_primary_10_1353_cj_2020_0052

This review of the two books listed below includes some highlights from those books.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Woke Gaming : Digital Challenges to Oppression and Social Injustice

BOOK

https://maine.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01MAINE_INST/n0nd3l/alma991033681649708681

"From #Gamergate to the daily experiences of marginalization among gamers, gaming is entangled with mainstream cultures of systematic exploitation and oppression. Whether visible in the persistent color line that shapes the production, dissemination, and legitimization of dominant stereotypes within the industry itself, or in the dehumanizing representations often found within game spaces, many video games perpetuate injustice and mirror the inequities and violence that permeate society as a whole. Drawing from the latest research and from popular games such as World of warcraft and Tomb raider, Woke gaming examines resistance to spaces of violence, discrimination, and microaggressions in gaming culture. The contributors of these essays identify strategies to detox gaming culture and orient players toward progressive ends, illustrating the power and potential of video games to become catalysts for social justice." Entire book is available to UMA students

through this link - you can even download PDFs of each section to read offline.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Gaming Representation: Race, Gender, and Sexuality in Video Games

BOOK

https://maine.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01MAINE_INST/n0nd3l/alma991046438239708681

"Gaming Representation' offers a timely and interdisciplinary call for greater inclusivity in video games. The issue of equality transcends the current focus in the field of Game Studies on code, materiality, and platforms. Journalists and bloggers have begun to hold the digital game industry and culture accountable for the discrimination routinely endured by female gamers, queer gamers, and gamers of color. Video game developers are responding to these critiques, but scholarly discussion of representation in games has lagged behind. Contributors to this volume examine portrayals of race, gender, and sexuality in a range of games, from casuals like Diner Dash, to indies like Journey and The Binding of Isaac, to mainstream games from the Grand Theft Auto, BioShock, Spec Ops, The Last of Us, and Max Payne franchises. Arguing that representation and identity function as systems in games that share a stronger connection to code and platforms than it may first appear, 'Gaming Representation' pushes gaming scholarship to new levels of inquiry, theorizing, and imagination." Entire book is available to UMA students through this link - you can even download an ePub or PDF.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Gaming at the edge : sexuality and gender at the margins of gamer culture

BOOK

https://maine.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01MAINE_INST/n0nd3l/alma991048180586708681

"Video games have long been seen as the exclusive territory of young, heterosexual white males. In a media landscape dominated by such gamers, players who do not fit this mold, including women, people of color, and LGBT people, are often brutalized in forums and in public channels in online play. Discussion of representation of such groups in games has frequently been limited and cursory. In contrast, Gaming at the Edge builds on feminist, queer, and postcolonial theories of identity and draws on qualitative audience research methods to make sense of how representation comes to matter. In Gaming at the Edge, Adrienne Shaw argues that video game players experience race, gender, and sexuality concurrently. She asks: How do players identify with characters? How do they separate identification and interactivity? What is the role of fantasy in representation? What is the importance of understanding market logic? In addressing these questions Shaw reveals how representation comes to matter to participants and offers a perceptive consideration of the high stakes in politics of representation debates. Putting forth a framework for talking about representation, difference, and diversity in an era in which user-generated content, individualized media consumption, and the blurring of producer/consumer roles has lessened the utility of traditional models of media representation analysis, Shaw finds new insight on the edge of media consumption with the invisible, marginalized gamers who are surprising in both their numbers and their influence in mainstream gamer culture." Entire book is available to UMA students through this link - you can even download PDFs of each section to read offline.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Polygamer Podcast

PODCAST

https://www.polygamer.net/

Polygamer was a monthly audio podcast that encouraged and celebrated equality and diversity in gaming by interviewing voices pushing for change. By speaking with traditionally marginalized voices, Polygamer provided a platform to discuss problems and seek perspective on matters of sexism, racism, ableism, ageism, and more, within our industry, our community, and our games. Although no longer being published, the archive is still available and worth checking out.

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LO 5: Students will gain insights into how technologies like artificial intelligence, virtual reality, and online connectivity shape gaming experiences.
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EXPLORE FURTHER

Sex, Sexy & Sexism: Fixing Gender Inequality in Gaming

CONFERENCE TALK VIDEO | 59 MIN

https://www.gamebits.net/2014/04/29/sex-sexy-and-sexism/

This 2014 PAX East panel was dedicated to fixing gender inequality within the gaming industry and culture. The diverse group of experts explores how subtle sexism and unconscious attitudes often marginalize women, manifesting in everything from exclusionary workplace dynamics to the graphic harassment and "silencing tactics" faced by female journalists and developers. While addressing the hyper-sexualization of female characters, the speakers advocate for narrative diversity and better management representation rather than censorship, arguing that a more inclusive environment is a financial necessity for reaching a broader audience. Ultimately, the discussion emphasizes that men must act as allies against harassment to transform gaming into a respectful space where diverse identities are reflected and valued.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

2024 State of the Game Industry

REPORT

https://drive.google.com/file/d/1GfmeYIVkpSuBDue8X5RShlG6sV4DMGK_/view?usp=sharing

This is the full report from which the Women in Games article in this week's required content got its information.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Women in Games

WEB SITE

https://www.womeningames.org/

An organization that believes that getting more women into games and esports should be framed as a national, international and strategic priority, a business case for stronger teams, better insights, innovative new products.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

10 Games With The Most Inclusive Character Creators

ARTICLE | 6 MIN

https://www.cbr.com/games-with-inclusive-character-creators/

This article examines the evolution of modern video games as they move away from restrictive binary gender selections to offer more inclusive character creators. By highlighting ten specific titles, the author illustrates how the industry is increasingly providing diverse options such as non-binary pronouns, gender-neutral clothing, and customizable physical attributes that aren't locked to a specific body type. The article is structured as a ranked list, transitioning from mainstream racing and simulation games to fantasy RPGs and indie projects, all while emphasizing the deepened connection players feel when they can authentically represent themselves. Ultimately, the piece serves as a guide to how creative developers are breaking down barriers to ensure that virtual identities can be as unique and varied as the people playing them.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Activision increased representation of women and non-binary people by 2 percentage points as it faces 2025 goal

ARTICLE

https://www.cnbc.com/2023/03/23/activision-increased-representation-of-women-and-non-binary-people-by-2-percentage-points.html

Activision has/had a goal to reach 35% for full-time non-binary and women workers by 2025; this 2023 article tells how they were doing at that time and the slides (https://www.activision.com/cdn/activisionblizzard/ABK-2022-Q1-Representation-Data.pdf) show where they were in 2022 along with their CEO’s statement about their goal; I haven’t found anything more recent saying how they are doing now.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Activision Blizzard to pay $54M to settle gender discrimination lawsuit, agrees to ensure ‘fair pay and promotion practices’

ARTICLE | HTTPS://FORTUNE.COM/2023/12/17/ACTIVISION-BLIZZARD-SETTLES-GENDER-DISCRIMINATION-LAWSUIT/

https://fortune.com/2023/12/17/activision-blizzard-settles-gender-discrimination-lawsuit/

Provides information about Activision Blizzard’s 2023 gender discrimination lawsuit settlement.

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LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.
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EXPLORE FURTHER

What do you think about gender inequality in GameDev?

REDDIT THREAD

https://www.reddit.com/r/GirlGamers/comments/1cdxuls/what_do_you_think_about_gender_inequality_in/

Interesting discussion about gender inequality in the game development industry. Keep in mind that Reddit threads change over time and that Reddit is a source of both great insight and great toxicity.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Qweerty Gamers

WEB SITE

https://www.qweertygamers.org/

Organization providing LGBTQIA+ resources, support, and networking access to advance visibility and representation in the global gaming industry.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

8 Oldest Games With Queer Representation

ARTICLE

https://www.thegamer.com/oldest-games-queer-lgbtq-representation/

Describes early games with queer characters, some positive and some not.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

They found GayBlade! (from Netflix's High Score series)

YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cWKtGJm60I8&ab_channel=Al%27sRetroGeekLab

Short video review of GayBlade, including game footage and a little about the history of the game as well as some explanation of HyperCard, the tool that was used to build GayBlade as well as the initial version of Myst. Or, if you prefer, you can play the game yourself (https://archive.org/details/gayblade).

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Caper in the Castro - Overview & Analysis of the First LGBT+ Video Game. Built in HyperCard for Mac

YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YTm92X47Q00&ab_channel=YesterYear%27sMacGames

Video review of Caper in the Castro including gameplay footage. Or, if you prefer, you can play the game yourself (https://archive.org/details/hypercard_caper-in-the-castro).

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The Kiss That Changed Video Games

ARTICLE

https://www.newyorker.com/tech/annals-of-technology/the-kiss-that-changed-video-games

This article from The New Yorker tells the story of how gay relationships became a part of The Sims. Originally suppressed by cautious executives, the game's inclusive coding was reintroduced by a new programmer who unknowingly used an outdated design document, leading to an unscripted lesbian kiss that captivated the 1999 E3 trade show. This pivotal moment not only saved the game from cancellation but also established a groundbreaking simulation where players could see diverse romantic identities represented as a normal part of domestic life. By contrasting this success with modern controversies in the industry, the article highlights the enduring legacy of The Sims as a pioneer for LGBTQ+ visibility in digital media.

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